Digital Scholarship in the Humanities, 2024, **00**, 1–13
https://doi.org/10.1093/llc/fqae010
Full Paper

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Towards a 'synergy' of text mining and critical discourse analysis: a corpus-assisted discourse study of imagining China in Hong Kong political discourse

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Abstract

This study proposes to incorporate text mining into critical discourse analysis (CDA) to give a corpus-assisted discourse study of the particular ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China in the public speeches of three former Chief Executives in the two decades after its handover. With the computer-assisted text-mining tool KH Coder, this study combines the methods of quantitative text mining and qualitative discourse analysis to examine their preferential ways of imagining China at different levels of discourse: (1) topics/themes, (2) discursive strategies, and (3) linguistic means and realizations. It generates illuminating findings concerning their preferential ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China as well as the analytic potential of incorporating text mining into CDA. It is expected that it can lead to more studies towards this endeavour.

Keywords: Chief Executive; national identity; Hong Kong; corpus-assisted discourse study; critical discourse analysis; text mining.

1. Introduction

It has been more than two decades since Hong Kong returned from 155 years' British colonial rule to the People's Republic of China (PRC) under the general framework of 'One Country, Two Systems' (Author 2022). The integration between Hong Kong and Chinese mainland was not smooth but full of dilemmas, tensions, conflicts, and setbacks (Chan 2000). As Ellis (2018: 90) states, 'Hong Kong is adrift between its British colonial past and its upcoming political reunification with the ancestral Chinese motherland'. It suffers from sustained identity crises, because it has to wrestle with the reconfiguration between national identity and local distinctiveness (Kit 2014). How to adapt to a rising China in a globalizing world has become a primary and constant concern of post-colonial Hong Kong. The formation of Hong Kong identities thus features 'a mixture of resistance and ambivalence resulting from contested national and local identities' (Kit 2014: 25).

Critical discourse analysis (CDA) views discourse as a form of social practice which is not only socially shaped but also socially shaping/constitutive. It is concerned about the 'ideologically permeated and often obscured structures of power, political control, dominance, as well as strategies of discriminatory inclusion and exclusion in language use' (Wodak et al. 2009: 8). Viewing national/group identity as an 'imagined community' and 'a mental construct' (Anderson 1983), CDA shows a strong interest in the discursive constructions of national identities in order to 'uncover manipulative manoeuvres in politics and the media' and 'heighten the awareness of the rhetorical strategies which are used to impose certain political beliefs, values and goals' (Wodak et al. 2009: 9). A growing number of CDA studies have been conducted on the discursive constructions of Hong Kong identities in post-colonial Hong Kong (Flowerdew 2002, 2012; Lam 2018). For example, Flowerdew (2002) examines rhetorical strategies and identity politics in the discourse of colonial withdrawal and reveals the use of some tropes by the last British governor of Hong Kong, Chris Patten, to serve his overall political goals and the manipulative nature of these tropes in his discursive construction of Britain's imperial/national history and identity.

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Under the general framework of 'One Country, Two Systems', the Chief Executive (CE) serves as the head of both the executive and the government in HKSAR (Wong 2017). He is supposed to serve two masters: the Chinese government and the HKSAR as suggested in the provision of the Basic Law (Poon 2007). The CE thus plays a leading role in defining Hong Kong's relations to China (Kress 1989; Flowerdew 2004). Although Ladegaard (2012) suggests that China is usually presented in Hong Kong public discourse as ingroup, there is little information about whether and how the former CEs vary in their particular ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China amid the changing socio-political contexts of post-colonial Hong Kong during the first two decades.

Previous CDA studies on Hong Kong identities used to rely on the qualitative examination of a few texts, for which CDA used to be challenged (Widdowson 1995, 2004). Some recent studies have resorted to corpus linguistic methods in the analysis of Hong Kong identities (Zhang and Mihelj 2012; Cheng and Lam 2013; Author et al. 2020). Nevertheless, most of these studies rely on traditional corpus linguistic methods, such as keywords, collocates, and concordance lines. They fail to take advantage of the recent development in computational linguistics and text mining which can be further explored for efficient and accurate analysis of the data (Poole 2022). This study combines text mining with CDA to give a corpus-assisted discourse study (CADS) of the particular ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China by three former CEs in their public speeches. It has three primary objectives: (1) to present an integrated analytic framework for the 'synergy' of text mining and CDA; (2) to examine their preferential ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China; (3) to explicate the underlying socio-political factors.

2. From critical discourse analysis to CADSs

2.1 Critical discourse analysis

With its origin in critical linguistics (Fowler et al. 1979; Hodge and Kress 1993), CDA differs from previous approaches to discourse analysis by focusing on struggles, conflicts, discrimination, and ideologies as manifested in language (Fairclough 1995; Wodak and Meyer 2016a). CDA does not presuppose a unified analytic framework or a ready-made method for doing CDA, but embraces the incorporation of any method or theory that can help to combine linguistic and social analyses and realize its research agenda (Wodak and Meyer 2016b). Due to different analytic frameworks proposed to combine linguistic and social analyses, CDA has developed into some closely related but distinct approaches, such as the socio-dialectic approach (Fairclough 2003), the socio-cognitive approach (van Dijk 2006), and the discourse-historical approach (DHA; Reisigl and Wodak 2016).

Being 'critical' does not mean 'detecting only the negative sides of social interaction and processes and painting a black and white picture of societies', but means 'making contradictions apparent' and the emphasis on 'self-reflection' (Wodak and Ludwig 1999: 12). CDA favours the thick linguistic analysis of texts by drawing on the concepts from different linguistic theories, such as systemic functional linguistics, pragmatics, and rhetoric (Fairclough 2003; Wodak and Meyer 2016b). This used to be achieved through qualitative analysis of a small sample of texts. The validity of CDA studies has thus been called into question and subject to extensive criticisms for a lack of methodological rigor and interpretation problems (Baker 2006; Mautner 2016). One frequently cited criticism concerns the generalizability, reliability, and representativeness of the findings since the analysis is based on a small number of texts arbitrarily selected or possibly cherry-picked to justify the researcher's perceived notions (Baker 2006).

Therefore, the methods and theories of corpus linguistics (CL) have been increasingly incorporated into CDA to present a combination of quantitative CL analysis and qualitative discourse analysis on a large sample of data, thus reducing researcher bias and providing empirical evidences for the findings (Fairclough 2001; Baker 2006). However, in an extensive review of previous corpus-based or corpus-driven CDA studies, Baker et al. (2008) state that most of them suffered from methodological imbalance and failed to explore the analytic potentials of combining the two disciplines. They argued for a methodological 'synergy' of CDA and CL in order to generate most illuminating findings concerning the data and contribute to the mutual development of both disciplines.

2.2 CADSs

A CADS approach has been known for its emphasis on the balanced combination or 'synergy' of CDA and CL (Partington, Morley, and Haarman 2004; Baker et al. 2008). The basic assumption is that a balanced combination of the methods and theories of CDA and CL can generate more significant and innovative findings which cannot be acquired otherwise and contribute to the mutual development of both disciplines (Morley and Bayley 2009). It does not presume pre-determined analytic methods and procedure but requires the analysts, mutually informed by methods and theories of CDA and CL, to identify the most appropriate analytic methods and procedure concerning the data (Baker et al. 2008). However, previous CADS studies used to rely on traditional CL methods, such as keywords,

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collocates, and concordance (Kamasa 2016; Poole 2022). Despite their proven value, these techniques are not optimal in investigating the overall topic structure and content of texts because they are primarily designed to examine lexical relationships (Murakami et al. 2017).

In response to this challenge, some researchers have started to take advantage of quantitative methods originating from machine learning and computational linguistics to give a critical discourse analysis of big data (Higuchi 2016, 2017; Törnberg and Törnberg 2016; Author et al. 2022; Poole 2022). Törnberg and Törnberg (2016) propose to combine CDA and topic modelling to analyse discursive connections between Islamophobia and anti-feminism on a large Internet forum. Lee (2019) combines co-occurrence analysis with topic modelling to analyse a corpus of Korean straight news reports. Chen, Hansen, and Vu (2021) perform a longitudinal semantic network analysis of mediation coverage in corpus newspapers from 1997 to 2018 to identify the major frames. These studies have demonstrated not only the possibilities but also the analytic potentials in incorporating text mining into CDA to identify prominent language patterns and reveal underlying ideologies in a large sample of texts. Nevertheless, these studies are strong in text mining but weak in linguistic analysis. More efforts need to be made to contribute to a balanced combination or 'synergy' of text mining and linguistic theories in CDA.

3. Data and methodology

3.1 Data collection

This study collects all public speeches of the three former CEs of Hong Kong, namely Chee-hwa Tung (1997–2005), Donald Tsang (2005–12), and Chun-ying Leung (2012–17). Three large corpora have been built by collecting their public speeches in the first two decades from the portal of the HKSAR government. This study only examines the English version of their public speeches. The English version is supposed to be more strategic in terms of branding, because it is subject to the extensive scrutiny of international readers and audience. Tung consists of 322 speeches (458,481 tokens), Tsang 215 speeches (267,014 tokens), and Leung 158 speeches (178,615 tokens).

3.2 DHA

This study is anchored in the theoretical paradigm of the DHA in CDA (Wodak et al. 2009). DHA underlines the examination of discourse in its socio-historical contexts and explicates the dialectic relations between discourse and society. Discourse can be constitutive in four aspects, namely, (1) 'the genesis, production and construction of particular social conditions', (2) 'the restoration, legitimation or relativization of a social status quo', (3) 'maintain[ing] and reproduc[ing] the status quo', and (4) 'transforming, dismantling or even destroying the status quo' (Wodak et al. 2009: 8). Viewing it as a relational term, DHA argues that identity 'never signifies anything static, unchanging, or substantial, but rather always an element situated in the flow of time, ever changing, something involved in a process' (Wodak et al. 2009: 11). Many DHA studies have thus traced the diachronic change of identity constructions during a specific period of time (Wodak et al. 2009). Particular attention is paid to the contradictions or inconsistencies in language use and reveal the manipulative character of discourse in identity constructions (Reisigl and Wodak 2016: 25).

DHA proposes to analyse texts at three different levels: (1) topics/themes; (2) discursive strategies; and (3) linguistic means (types) and realizations (tokens). It defines 'strategy' as 'a more or less intentional plan of practice (including discursive practices) adopted to achieve a particular social, political, psychological or linguistic goal' (Reisigl and Wodak 2016: 33). Wodak et al. (2009) identify four discursive strategies for identity constructions, including: (1) construction; (2) perpetuation or justification; (3) transformation; and (4) destruction. Construction strategies concern the construction and establishment of national/group identities by 'promoting unification, identification and solidarity, as well as differentiation' (Wodak et al. 2009: 33); perpetuation strategies concern the consolidation and reproduction of a threatened national/group identity; justification strategies involve the justification or legitimation of a social status quo; transformation strategies refer to the transformation of a well-established national/group identity into another identity, while destruction strategies involve the dismantling of an existing national/group identity without proposing a new one. Each strategy can be realized by different linguistic means, such as tropes/metaphors, and topoi. As Wodak et al. (2009) suggest, the same trope or topos can be used for different strategies. This warrants a close examination of their linguistic realizations in specific contexts of use.

3.3 Analytic methods and procedure

Drawing on DHA, this study aims to answer three research questions:

(1) To what extent does China emerge as a prominent topic in the three former CE's speeches?
(2) How do they vary in the choice of specific discursive strategies in their imagining of Hong Kong's relations to China?
(3) What are the socio-political factors behind their particular ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China?

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The free text-mining tool KH Coder will be used for the analysis of the three corpora. KH coder is a free text-mining software developed for quantitative content analysis by Koichi Higuchi at Ritsumeikan University in 2001 (Higuchi 2016, 2017). KH Coder uses 'Stanford POS Tagger to extract words from English data, R for statistical analysis, and MySQL to organize and retrieve the data' (Higuchi 2016: 78). It consists of a range of functions, such as frequency list, key word in context concordance, key term extractions, word association, correspondence analysis, multi-dimensional scaling, hierarchical cluster analysis, co-occurrence network analysis, and self-organizing map (Higuchi 2016, 2017).

This study starts with an automatic extraction of words from the three corpora to get an overview of the data (Higuchi 2016, 2017). It can reduce researcher bias and discover data features that have not been previously observed (Higuchi 2016). This can be achieved through an automatic co-occurrence network analysis of the three corpora. Co-occurrence concerns the tendency for high-frequency words to occur in proximity to each other in a specific unit of text, that is, sentence, paragraph or text (Grayson et al. 2016). The relationships between co-occurring words can suggest the content/topics/themes/frames of a corpus. KH Coder can visualize co-occurring words with a network and draw thicker lines between strong co-occurring words (see Figs. 1–3). By default, KH Coder generates a network by connecting sixty pairs of the most strongly co-occurring words by lines (Higuchi 2016). Words not connected by lines are removed from the diagram. In the co-occurrence network, several groups of words strongly connected with one another are automatically detected and displayed with different colours. The primary purpose is to see not only the key topics in the three corpora but also the role *China* plays in the three corpora.

This is followed by a word association analysis of the words co-occurring with Hong Kong and those tokens referring to China in a sentence. This can be achieved through creating a coding rule for China, which consists of three tokens, that is, *China*, *Chinese*, and *mainland*. Coding of KH Coder is based on the idea of extracting concepts from a document rather than classifying a document into a single category (Higuchi 2017). These strong occurring words are supposed to contribute to constructing Hong Kong's relations to China. The strength of association is measured by the values of Jaccard coefficients. The Jaccard coefficient is calculated as the number of sentences containing A and B, divided by the number of sentences containing A or B. The value varies between 0 and 1. The larger the value, the stronger the degree of co-occurrence and association (Higuchi 2017).

Word association analysis can reveal the tropes and topoi used for constructing Hong Kong's relations to China in a sentence. It is followed by a close qualitative analysis of these tropes and topoi in these identified sentences to identify the different strategies used. The analysis is mutually informed by both text mining and CDA. While text mining can contribute to the efficient processing of large samples of texts and generate the prominent language patterns, DHA can contribute to the choice of the most relevant analytic techniques at different levels of analysis, down-sampling the data, and suggest entry points for further detailed linguistic analysis. The findings will be discussed in terms of the professional persona of the three former CEs and the changing socio-political contexts of Hong Kong. It is hoped that a balanced combination of quantitative text mining and qualitative discourse analysis can generate illuminating findings concerning the particular ways of imagining China by the three former CEs.

4. Findings

4.1 Analysis of topics and themes in the three corpora

In order to confirm whether China serves as a prominent topic in the three corpora, this study starts with an automatic co-occurrence network analysis of the three corpora. We focus on the default top sixty pairs of strongly co-occurring words. Words are filtered by POS and only Noun, ProperNoun, Adj, Adv, and Verb are screened out for visualization. Three co-occurrence networks are thus produced (see Figs. 1–3).

As Figs. 1–3 show, *Hong Kong*, *mainland*, and *China* serve as prominent words in three corpora. However, they show different associations with each other. In Tung, *Hong Kong* (6,271) has a strong association with *China* (1,971) rather than *mainland* (926), and *mainland* and *China* do not have a strong association with each other. In Tsang, *Hong Kong* (4,270) does not have a strong association with either *mainland* (978) or *China* (854), but *mainland* and *China* have a strong association with each other. In Leung, *Hong Kong* (3,901) has a strong association with both *mainland* (972) and *China* (1,050). Therefore, Tung foregrounds Hong Kong's relations to China rather than China's mainland. Tsang puts the primary emphasis on Hong Kong and downplays Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland. Leung foregrounds Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland.

Besides, they also vary in prominent themes. In Fig. 1, the most prominent themes are Themes 1 and 2. Theme 1 underlines Hong Kong's relations to China, while Theme 2 foregrounds mainland market and opportunities, international and Asian financial market, and the improvement of education and life qualities. In Fig. 2, The most prominent themes are also Themes 1

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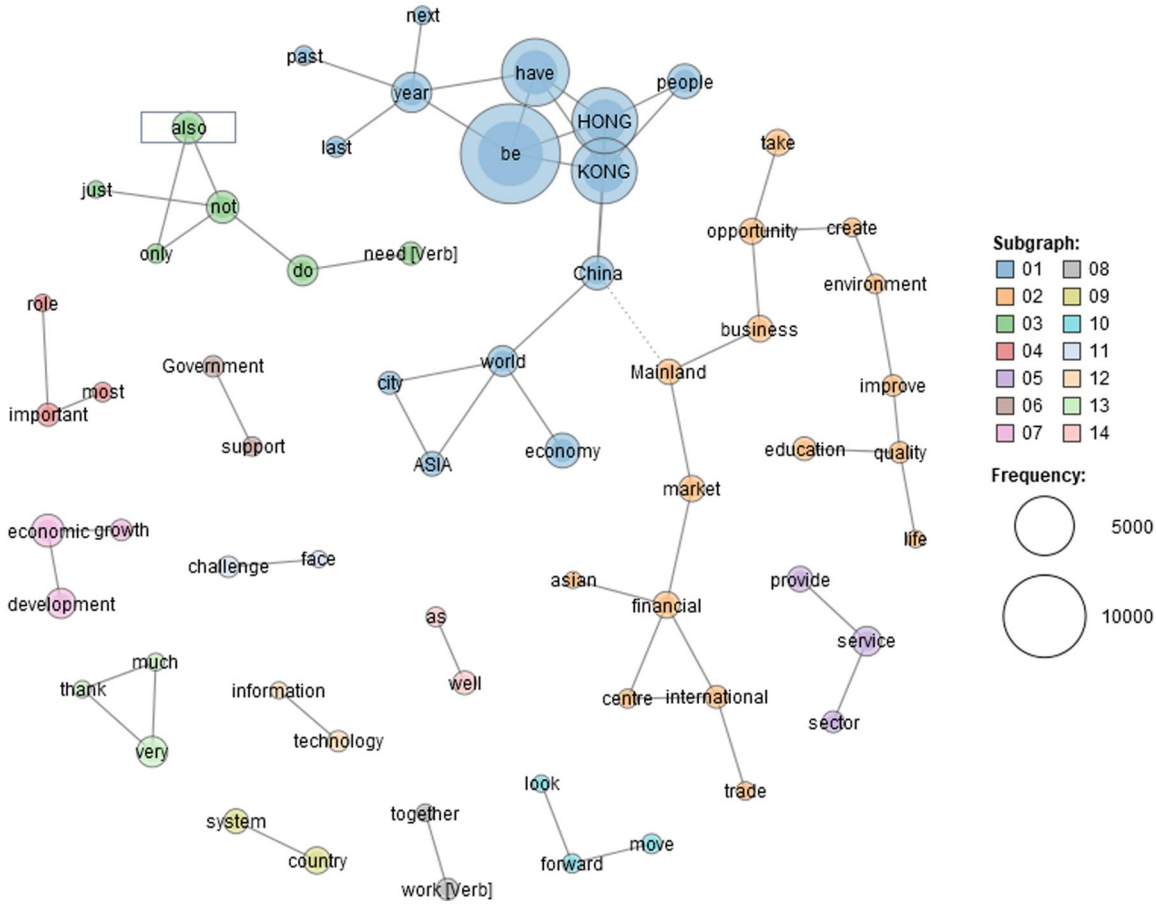


Figure 1. Co-occurrence network of Tung.

and 2. Theme 1 foregrounds mainland China, international/global financial centre/market/crisis, mainland companies, trade and investment. Theme 2 foregrounds Hong Kong and new opportunities. In Fig. 3, the most prominent theme is Theme 1. Theme 1 foregrounds Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland and the rest of the world. Therefore, Fig. 3 tends to be more focused on Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland.

Finally, they also vary with prominent topics. In Fig. 1, Tung foregrounds 'One Country, Two Systems' (Theme 9), economic growth and development (Theme 7), information and technology (Theme 12), and the challenges Hong Kong faces (Theme 11). He is also concerned about the future of Hong Kong, as can be seen from Theme 10 (*move*, *forward*, and *look*) and building solidarity, as can be seen from Theme 8 (*work* and *together*). By contrast, Tsang prefers to underline economic growth and development (Theme 6), and business and trade (Theme 1). Leung also underlines 'economic development and growth' (Theme 4), 'Renminbi trade and investment' (Theme 3), 'innovation and technology' (Theme 10), and 'financial service' (Theme 8). In addition, he also underlines 'One Country, Two Systems' (Theme 6), and the 'Belt and Road' initiative.

4.2 Analysis of the words co-occurring with *Hong Kong* and **China*

Table 1 shows top thirty co-occurring words of both *Hong Kong* and **China* (including *China*, *Chinese*, and *mainland*) in a sentence. The most prominent topics associated with **China* and *Hong Kong* in three corpora are business and trade as can be seen from such words as *business*, *market*, *economic*, *company*, *trade*, CEPA, *investment*, *Renminbi*, *financial*, *firm*, and *investor*. Tung also highlights Hong Kong's return to PRC on 1 July 1997 (i.e. *return*, *people*, *July*), China's accession to WTO (i.e. WTO), and 'One Country, Two Systems' (i.e. *country* and *system*). Tsang foregrounds CEPA (i.e. CEPA), and Hong Kong's status as a global/international financial centre

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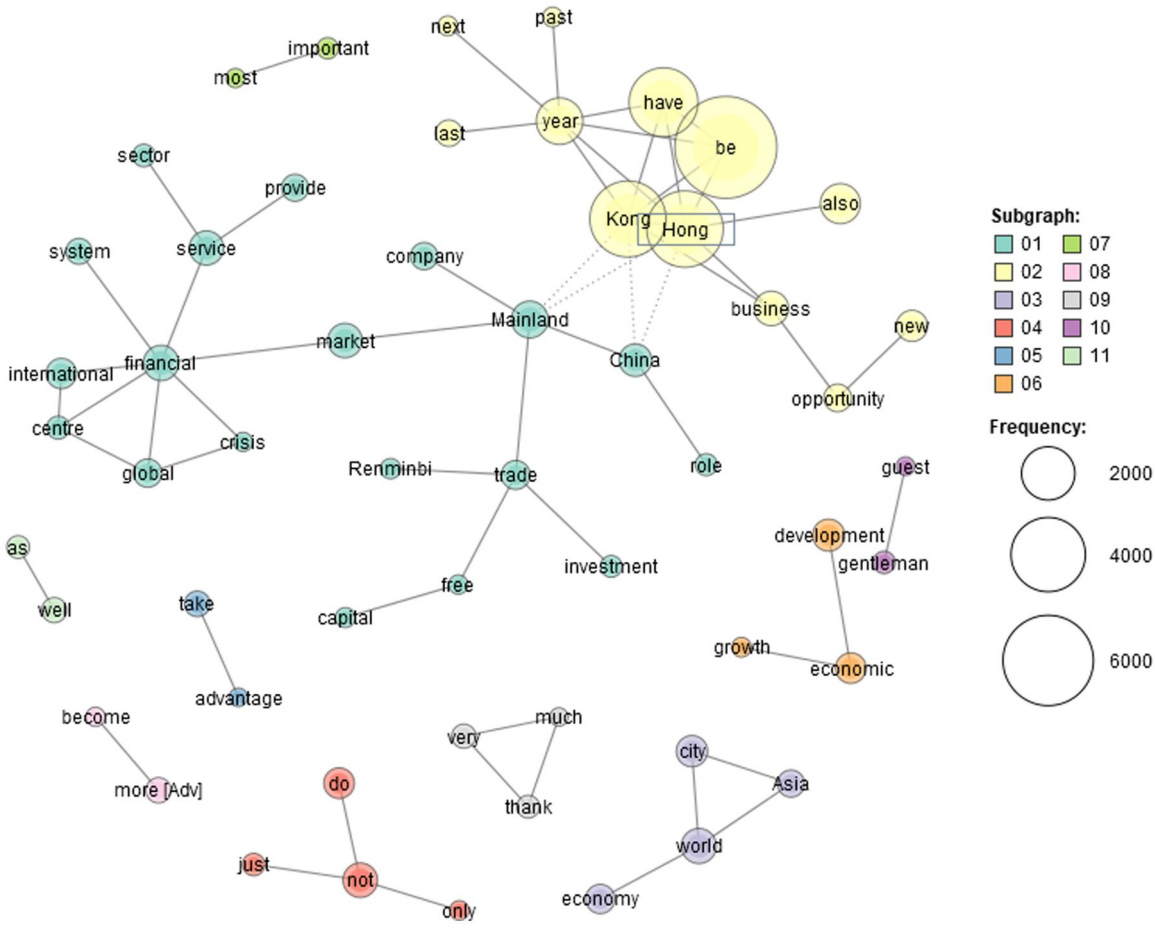


Figure 2. Co-occurrence network of Tsang.

(i.e. *global*, *international*, *financial*, *centre*). Leung underlines Hong Kong's position as a global financial/international centre (i.e. *global*, *international*, *financial*, *centre*) as well as 'One Country, Two Systems' (i.e. *country* and *system*).

Apart from these topical words, several words can be identified for representing the relations between Hong Kong and Chinese mainland, including *gateway*, *super-connector*, *opportunity*, and *advantage*. Examples are as follows:

(1) Hong Kong is fortunate, as we are the ***gateway*** of the fastest growing economy in the world.
(2) These require us to fine-tune our role as a ***super-connector*** linking the Mainland of China and the rest of the world.
(3) After a detailed review of our competitive ***advantages***, our vision is for Hong Kong to become one of the major cities of China and to be the World City of Asia.
(4) The reunification of Hong Kong with China has opened up new ***opportunities***.

According to *Oxford English Learner's Dictionaries* online, *gateway* is defined as 'a place through which you can go to reach another larger place', whereas *connector* is defined as 'a thing that links two or more things together'. Therefore, the use of *gateway* in Tung and Tsang underlines the spatial relations between Hong Kong and China. *Gateway* and *super-connector* can be regarded as alternative metaphors for conceptualizing Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland, since 'spatial, territorial, and local dimensions … are likewise significant in this discursive construction of national identity' (Wodak et al. 2009: 26). Nevertheless, *super-connector* underlines Hong Kong's mediating role between Chinese mainland and the rest of the world. Furthermore, the former is unidirectional, while the latter is bidirectional. It suggests Hong Kong's changing relation to China.

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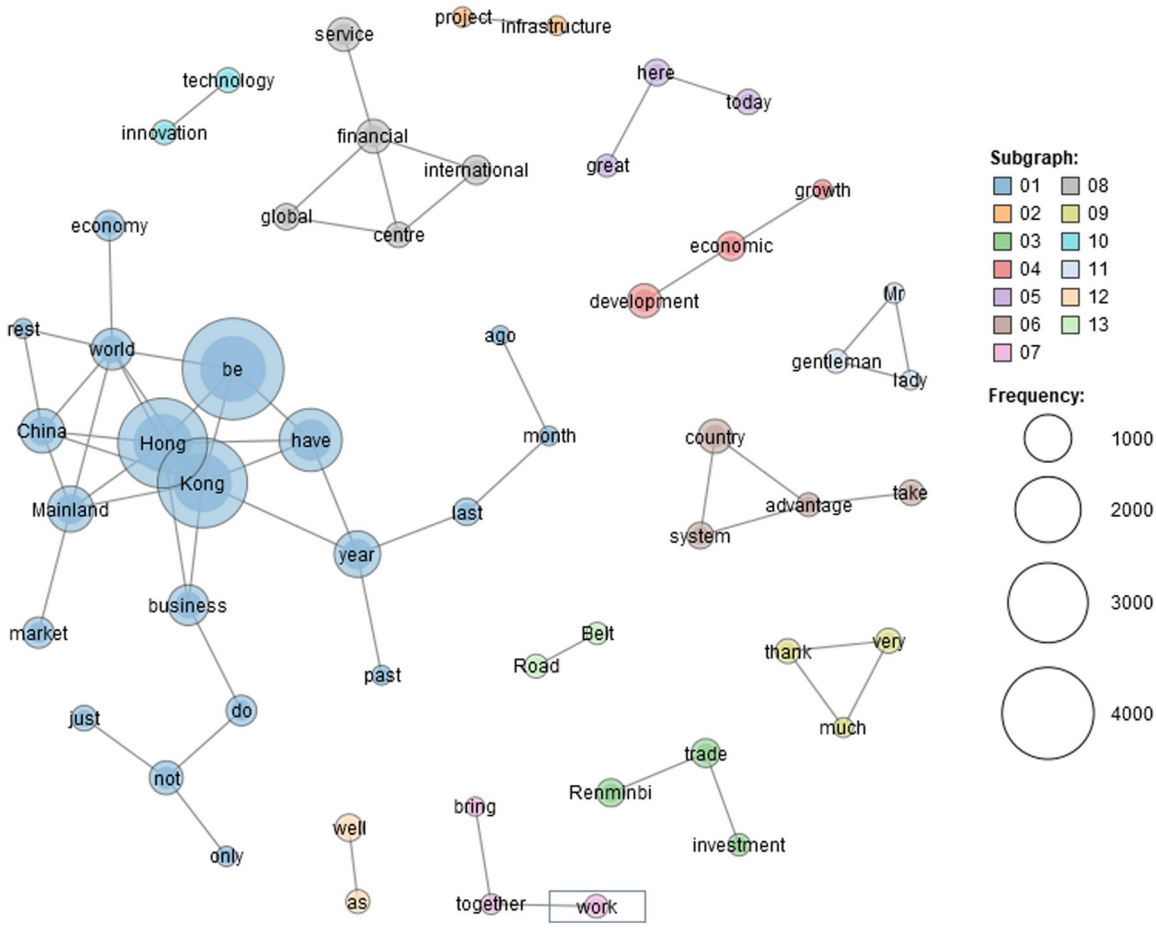


Figure 3. Co-occurrence network of Leung.

According to *Oxford Learner's Dictionaries* online, *opportunity* is defined as 'a time when a particular situation makes it possible to do or achieve something', while *advantage* is defined as 'a thing that helps you to be better or more successful than other people'. While *opportunity** underlines potential benefits, whereas *advantage** foregrounds actual benefits. The choice of the topos of opportunity and advantage can suggest the preference for constructing China as an opportunity or advantage to Hong Kong and represent the typical justification strategies for justifying being part of China. Tung's preference for *opportunity** over *advantage** suggests Tung's preference for constructing China as an opportunity rather than as an advantage to Hong Kong, while Tsang's and Leung's preference for *advantage** over *opportunity** indicates their preferences for constructing China as an advantage rather than an opportunity. In other words, Tung puts more emphasis on the potential benefits of being part of China, whereas Tsang and Leung prefer to highlight the actual benefits of returning to China. The following sections further examine the four words in their sentences to investigate how they contribute to the constructions of China in the three corpora.

4.3 Analysis of the tropes of *gateway** and *super-connector**

A close examination of *gateway* in Tung and Tsang also reveals that they show preferences for different strategies. Tung prefers both construction and perpetuation strategies in the representation of Hong Kong as a gateway to China. Construction strategies are used to construct Hong Kong's spatial advantage to be a gateway to China. In these sentences, *gateway* tends to be predicated by such expressions as *natural* (5), *perfect* (3), and *ideally* (2). Examples are as follows:

(5) Where indeed, but right here in Hong Kong, the natural ***gateway*** to China.
(6) We are ideally located as a ***gateway*** to the Mainland of China to take advantage in the rapidly developing China's economy.

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Table 1. Co-occurring words of *Hong Kong* and **China* in three corpora.

	Tung			Tsang			Leung		
Rank	word	Freq.	Jac.	word	Freq.	Jac.	word	Freq.	Jac.
1	*business*	104 (0.118)	0.064	*market*	120 (0.162)	0.090	*world*	132 (0.167)	0.095
2	*ASIA*	89 (0.101)	0.059	*company*	94 (0.127)	0.087	*company*	84 (0.106)	0.084
3	*market*	83 (0.094)	0.052	*CEPA*	65 (0.088)	0.076	*market*	89 (0.113)	0.082
4	*economic*	106 (0.120)	0.050	*role*	72 (0.097)	0.075	*business*	108 (0.137)	0.080
5	*country*	81 (0.092)	0.048	*trade*	78 (0.106)	0.067	*rest*	63 (0.080)	0.074
6	*opportunity*	76 (0.086)	0.047	*business*	91 (0.123)	0.065	*international*	76 (0.096)	0.072
7	*Region*	46 (0.052)	0.044	*international*	79 (0.107)	0.064	*super-connector*	59 (0.075)	0.069
8	*city*	61 (0.069)	0.044	*financial*	86 (0.116)	0.061	*advantage*	63 (0.080)	0.067
9	*world*	84 (0.095)	0.043	*economic*	72 (0.097)	0.057	*CEPA*	56 (0.071)	0.065
10	*development*	80 (0.091)	0.041	*centre*	52 (0.070)	0.053	*country*	70 (0.089)	0.060
11	*company*	47 (0.053)	0.041	*advantage*	45 (0.061)	0.051	*trade*	62 (0.078)	0.059
12	*international*	58 (0.066)	0.041	*service*	67 (0.091)	0.050	*role*	51 (0.065)	0.055
13	*special*	45 (0.051)	0.040	*Renminbi*	45 (0.061)	0.050	*financial*	63 (0.080)	0.055
14	*part*	46 (0.052)	0.040	*gateway*	37 (0.050)	0.049	*service*	58 (0.073)	0.050
15	*WTO*	38 (0.043)	0.039	*special*	39 (0.053)	0.047	*economic*	53 (0.067)	0.049
16	*return*	36 (0.041)	0.039	*access*	37 (0.050)	0.045	*Asia*	49 (0.062)	0.047
17	*Administrative*	39 (0.044)	0.038	*global*	52 (0.070)	0.044	*other*	50 (0.063)	0.045
18	*economy*	88 (0.100)	0.038	*firm*	37 (0.050)	0.044	*global*	44 (0.056)	0.043
19	*people*	87 (0.099)	0.037	*investment*	40 (0.054)	0.042	*centre*	42 (0.053)	0.043
20	*role*	42 (0.048)	0.036	*co-operation*	36 (0.049)	0.041	*people*	49 (0.062)	0.042
21	*system*	55 (0.063)	0.036	*opportunity*	46 (0.062)	0.039	*overseas*	36 (0.046)	0.041
22	*year*	98 (0.111)	0.035	*Asia*	45 (0.061)	0.039	*opportunity*	45 (0.057)	0.041
23	*advantage*	38 (0.043)	0.034	*enterprise*	32 (0.043)	0.038	*development*	50 (0.063)	0.041
24	*major*	38 (0.043)	0.032	*investor*	31 (0.042)	0.038	*city*	45 (0.057)	0.040
25	*new*	57 (0.065)	0.031	*Administrative*	29 (0.039)	0.038	*system*	38 (0.048)	0.037
26	*gateway*	28 (0.032)	0.031	*overseas*	30 (0.041)	0.036	*part*	35 (0.044)	0.037
27	*important*	45 (0.051)	0.031	*foreign*	29 (0.039)	0.036	*Chinese*	29 (0.037)	0.035
28	*trade*	37 (0.042)	0.031	*more*	44 (0.060)	0.035	*Renminbi*	36 (0.046)	0.035
29	*July*	30 (0.034)	0.030	*unique*	29 (0.039)	0.034	*investor*	27 (0.034)	0.031
30	*successful*	34 (0.039)	0.029	*country*	39 (0.053)	0.034	*Partnership*	25 (0.032)	0.031

Tung also resort to perpetuation strategies to consolidate Hong Kong's relations to China. They underline that Hong Kong has been a gateway to China's mainland for a long time. In these sentences, Hong Kong's relations to China have been perpetuated in terms of time. This can be attributed to the fact that there are widespread concerns about the diminishing role of Hong Kong after its return to China. Examples are as follows:

(7) For a long time, Hong Kong's success had been built on being the only ***gateway*** to the Mainland and China's gateway to the world.
(8) Hong Kong, long served as a ***gateway*** to the Mainland of China, will be able to perform the role in promoting trade and investment between India and China, and we
(9) Furthermore, historically, Hong Kong's prosperity was built on being the world's premier ***gateway*** to the rest of China, and China's gateway to the whole world.

By contrast, Tsang shows the overwhelming preference for construction strategies in his representation of Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland by constructing Hong Kong's *premier* and *international* statuses as a gateway to China's mainland. *Gateway* tends to be pre-modified by such adjectives as *premier* (21), and *international* (13). Examples are as follows:

(10) We are the *premier international* ***gateway*** to the Mainland of China market.
(11) As well as a *premier* ***gateway*** to Mainland China for trade, Hong Kong is also China's global financial centre.

Although perpetuation strategies have also been used, the occurrences are very few. They often occur with construction strategies in Tsang to highlight the premier and international statuses of Hong Kong to China. Examples are as follows:

(12) Over the years, Hong Kong has fine-tuned its role as the *premier international* ***gateway*** to the Mainland.

Although *gateway* is also used to construct and perpetuate Hong Kong's position as a gateway to China's

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mainland, it is constructed in a bidirectional rather than unidirectional way, as in the following:

(13) Allow me to expand on Hong Kong's role as a *pre-eminent* ***gateway*** to and from the Mainland.

Besides, Leung resorts to transformational strategies by replacing *gateway* with *super-connector* to represent Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland. This can be explained in terms of the changing role of Hong Kong in a globalizing world, as more corporations from China's mainland go abroad with the growing importance of China's economy in the world, as in the following:

(14) We are therefore the '***super-connector***' between the rest of the country and the rest of the world.

4.4 Analysis of the topos of *advantage* and *opportunity*

This section gives a close analysis of the use of *opportunity** and *advantage** in their specific contexts to show how they are used to construct Hong Kong's relations to China. Particular attention is paid to three aspects: (1) the attribute (i.e. the description of opportunities or advantages), (2) the contributor (i.e. the source of opportunities or advantages), and (3) the beneficiary (i.e. the benefiter of opportunities or advantages).

4.4.1 *Analysis of Tung*

Tung prefers to underline the new opportunities brought by 'Hong Kong's reunification with China' and 'China's accession into the WTO'. Tung prefers to foreground the new and unprecedented opportunities, since *opportunity** tends to be pre-modified by such adjectives as *new* (17), *enormous* (4), *significant* (3), *great/greater* (3), *unprecedented* (2), and *immense* (2). Hong Kong is represented as the primary beneficiary of new opportunities. Examples are as follows:

(15) The reunification of Hong Kong with China has opened up *new opportunities*.
(16) China's accession to the WTO will also bring *immense business opportunities* to Hong Kong.

However, Tung was ambiguous about the advantages Hong Kong enjoys. This can be revealed in not only the few occurrences of *advantage** but also its specific use. Among the total thirty-four occurrences, fourteen out of thirty-four (41%) occur as the verb phrase *take* ***advantage*** *of*, and twenty (59%) occur as the head of the nominal group, for example, *our competitive* ***advantages*** (Halliday 1994). While these sentences with *take advantage of* also represent China as the primary contributor and Hong Kong as the primary beneficiary, they do not mean Hong Kong really enjoys the advantage brought by China, since *take advantage of* only means *make the use of*. However, Tung prefers to underline Hong Kong as 'well prepared' or 'strategically located' to make use of the opportunities brought by China. However, there is little knowledge whether Hong Kong can turn these opportunities into its advantages. Examples are as follows:

(17) Hong Kong is strategically located to *take advantage of*, and contribute to, China's modernisation programme.

As regards twenty occurrences of *advantage* in its nominal groups, *advantage** tends to be predicated by such adjectives as *competitive* (5), *greatest* (3), *great* (1), *enormous* (1), *immense* (1), and '*first mover*' (1). Tung tends to underline Hong Kong's competitive advantages to be one of the major cities of China or the World City of Asia. Even though they also represent Hong Kong as the primary beneficiary and China as the primary contributor, the contributors tend to be generally represented as 'our links with the mainland China', 'a very unique relationship of Hong Kong with the mainland China', and 'our economic link with the Mainland'. The use of the vague word *link* further confirms Tung's uncertainty or ambiguity about the benefits of being part of China, as in the following:

(18) One of the *greatest advantages* in developing Hong Kong into a world class city is our links with the Mainland China.

Among them, only two instances underline the political advantage of 'One Country, Two Systems'. However, its contributions are represented in a mitigating way with the expressions 'necessary competitive advantage' and 'helps to'. Examples are as follows:

(19) 'One country, Two systems' will also give Hong Kong the ***necessary competitive*** *advantage* as we become Asia's World City and one of the major cities of China.
(20) The principle of 'One country, Two systems' **helps to** maintain our respective strengths and *advantages*, and provides a solid basis for Hong Kong to build synergy with the Mainland to open up the unbounded opportunities brought by innovation.

Unlike Tsang and Leung, he even expresses worries about the decreasing advantages of Hong Kong as China continues to open up, as in the following:

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(21) As China continues to open up, some will say Hong Kong's *competitive advantage* will narrow.

4.4.2 *Analysis of Tsang*

Tsang is very certain about the advantage Hong Kong enjoys. This can also be revealed in both the attributes and specific uses of *advantage**. Among the total forty-seven occurrences of *advantage**, thirty-five (74%) appear as the head of a nominal group, while twelve (26%) appear in the verb phrase *take advantage of*. *Advantage** in the nominal group tends to be predicated by such adjectives as *unique* (7), *many* (3), *biggest* (3), *China* (3), *global* (3), *first-mover* (2), and *unrivalled* (1). Therefore, Tsang prefers to highlight the unique and unrivalled advantages Hong Kong enjoys. Tsang also represents the mainland as the main contributor of advantages and prefers to underline the advantages brought by Hong Kong's geographical position to the mainland and the trade pact (i.e. CEPA) between Hong Kong and the Mainland. The contributors of advantages are represented in such ways as 'as a gateway to mainland China and East Asia', 'a unique free trade pact between the Mainland and Hong Kong', 'a free trade pact between Hong Kong and the Mainland', and 'our unrivalled role in bridging the Mainland to the international market'.

(22) A *unique advantage* for Hong Kong is our unrivalled role in bridging the Mainland, the world's fastest growing large economy, to the international market …

Besides, he even uses the nominal form of *China advantages* (3) and *global advantages* (3) to represent the advantages brought by China and the world, as in the following:

(23) We like to think of Hong Kong as a place where '*global advantages*' and '*China advantages*' converge.

There are only two occurrences of *advantage** which underline the advantages Hong Kong enjoys as a SAR of the PRC after its reunification with the country.

Similar findings can also be found in the use of *take advantage of* (12). The main contributors are still CEPA and economic opportunities. Besides, Tsang prefers to represent global corporations as the main contributors (7) rather than the local Hong Kong corporations (3), as in the following:

(24) **Global**: I would like to encourage Belgian companies, particularly small- and medium-sized businesses, to *take **advantage** of* CEPA and use Hong Kong as their base for doing business in China and the rest of Asia.
(25) **Local**: For example, Hong Kong's watch and clock industry has been able to *take **advantage** of* CEPA to tap the vast Mainland market.

This can also be seen from the use of opportunities (47), with thirty five occurrences representing global corporations but only twelve occurrences representing Hong Kong or Hong Kong corporations as the beneficiaries, as in the following:

(26) **Global**: By staging your meeting here, the world's senior shipping executives have a chance to explore business ***opportunities*** in Hong Kong and the Mainland of China.
(27) **Local**: We must make the best of these ***opportunities*** to create a favourable environment for our services industry to enter the huge Mainland market.

Besides, they also represent CEPA as the main contributor. In other words, they still foreground Hong Kong's economic relations with China. Furthermore, Tsang foregrounds not only the quality but also the quantity of opportunities, because *opportunities* tend to be pre-modified by such adjectives as *new* (5), *many* (3), *tremendous* (2), *more* (2), and *greater* (2).

4.2.3 *Analysis of Leung*

Leung differs from Tsang and Tung in not only the certainty of advantages but also the nature of advantages. Leung is even more certain about the advantages enjoyed by Hong Kong. Among the total sixty three instances of *advantage**, only twelve (19%) appear as *take advantage of*, while fifty one (81%) appear as the head of a nominal group. For *advantage** in the nominal group, *advantage* tends to be pre-modified by such adjectives as *combined* (8), *China* (7), *unique* (2), and *distinct* (2). They underline the advantages of 'One Country' and 'Two Systems' (17) as well as 'China advantages' (7). In other words, Leung prefers to underline political advantages rather than economic or geographical advantages. Besides, the nominal group *China advantages* is more frequently used in Leung (7) than in Tsang (3) to foreground the advantages brought by China, but the nominal group *global advantages* cannot be found in Leung. Examples are as follows:

(28) It enables Hong Kong to enjoy the *combined **advantages*** of both 'one country' and 'two systems'—to maintain our internationality, while deepening integration with the Mainland of
(29) All this is our '*China **advantage***', but it is only half of the story.

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This can also be seen from the verb phrase *take advantage of*. The main contributors are still political policies, such as 'Hong Kong's unique opportunities as a Special Administrative Region of China', and 'the "Belt-Road" initiatives', as in the following:

(30) Hong Kong, as the unrivalled super-connector between the Mainland of China and the rest of the world, is well-positioned to *take* ***advantage*** *of* the 'Belt-Road' initiatives.
(31) And we will *take full* ***advantage*** *of* Hong Kong's unique opportunities as a Special Administrative Region of China under the 'One Country, Two Systems' formula.

As regards *opportunity** (45), Leung also represents the 'Belt-Road' Initiatives as the main contributors, but unlike Tsang, Leung gives equal representations of global (22) and local (21) corporations as the beneficiaries, as in the following:

(32) **Local**: In doing so, it has supported *Hong Kong businesses* to explore new markets, to tap *new* ***opportunities*** all over the world, including the Mainland of China.
(33) **Global**: Hong Kong serves as a multiple adaptor that helps *companies from Europe and around the world* to plug into the *huge* ***opportunities*** in the Mainland of China and further afield across Asia.

Moreover, Leung tends to underline the extent and quantity of opportunities, because *opportunity** tends to be pre-modified by such adjectives as *huge* (6), *many* (2), *new* (2), *more* (1), *numerous* (1), *tremendous* (1), *vast* (1), and *unique* (1). This further confirms Leung's certainty about the benefits brought by China's mainland.

5. Discussion and conclusion

To sum up, although all three CEs foreground Hong Kong's relations to China in their public speeches, they vary in their specific ways which can be detected in their preferences for topics/themes, discursive strategies, and linguistic means and realizations. While China emerges as a prominent theme in their speeches, Tung prefers to foreground the relations between Hong Kong and China, and Tsang prefers to focus more on Hong Kong, Leung on Hong Kong's relations to China's mainland. They also show different preferences for the tropes of gateway and super-connector and the topoi of opportunity and advantage. While Tung and Tsang prefer to resort to the metaphor of gateway to construct Hong Kong's geographical relation to China, Leung prefers the metaphor of super-connector to foreground Hong Kong's meditating role between China's mainland and the rest of the world. Tung prefers to use construction and perpetuation strategies to foreground Hong Kong's geographical advantage to be a gateway to China's mainland, while Tsang shows an overwhelming preference for construction strategies to foreground Hong Kong's premier and international status to be a gateway to China's mainland.

The preference for the topoi of opportunity and advantage also suggests the justification strategies for constructing Hong Kong's relations to China. Tung was ambiguous about the benefits, so he prefers to foreground the opportunities rather than advantages. Tsang and Leung were certain about the benefits, so they foreground advantages over opportunities. However, Tsang prefers to foreground the advantages and opportunities brought by Hong Kong's economic relations to China's mainland, Leung prefers to foreground the advantages and opportunities brought by political policies, 'One Country, Two Systems' and the 'Belt-Road' Initiatives in particular. In addition, Tsang prefers to underline the opportunities for global corporations, whereas Leung tends to foreground the opportunities for both global and local corporations.

This can be explained in terms of the changing socio-political contexts of Hong Kong during the two decades. Tung was the first CE of Hong Kong. When he took office, there were widespread concerns about Hong Kong's future under 'One Country, Two Systems' (Chu 2011). Therefore, he was ambiguous about the benefits China would bring to Hong Kong. However, as the first CE of Hong Kong, he needed to project a promising future for Hong Kong by underlining the new opportunities available for Hong Kong rather than the advantages. Perpetuation strategies had been frequently used to consolidate public trust in Hong Kong's position as a gateway to China.

When Tsang succeeded Tung as the second CE, the Chinese government relinquished its laissez faire policies to take a more proactive approach in Hong Kong by introducing some economic policies which contribute to further integration between Hong Kong and China's mainland, for example, the CEPA (Fung and Chan 2017). Therefore, Hong Kong enjoyed fast economic development during this period. Besides, with increasing economic integration between Hong Kong and China's mainland, another wave of localism began to rise during this period (Author et al. 2020). That may explain why Tsang preferred to align with the public by putting more emphasis on Hong Kong and underlining Hong Kong's premier and international status compared to China's mainland (Chu 2011).

However, when Leung assumed office in 2012, dramatic changes had taken place to Hong Kong (Ku

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2018). On the one hand, China's mainland has made tremendous achievements in the last decade after its entry into WTO. The previous privileges Hong Kong enjoyed in its economy had been eroded by the burgeoning economic development in China's mainland. China's mainland was no longer satisfied with its status as a destination for foreign investment as more and more big corporations go abroad to look for investment opportunities. This transformed Hong Kong's role from a unidirectional gateway to China's mainland into a bidirectional super-connector between China's mainland and the rest of the world. Besides, known for his close relations to the Chinese government, Leung further strengthened Hong Kong's political ties to China's mainland. That explains why he preferred to underline the advantages of 'One Country' and 'Two Systems'.

Therefore, a combination of quantitative content analysis and qualitative discourse analysis can present not only an overview of the three corpora but also reveals the prominent discursive strategies and linguistic means and realizations in the three former CEs' particular ways of imagining China. In this study, co-occurrence network analysis provides the empirical evidence for the significance of China in the public speeches of the three former CEs, thus warranting further analysis of the relations between Hong Kong and China in the three corpora. Word association analysis provides an efficient method to zoom in on the specific discursive strategies used for constructing Hong Kong's relations in sentences. However, DHA provides both the analytic framework of this study and the identification of some important language patterns generated by text mining for further close linguistic analysis. Therefore, quantitative content analysis and qualitative discourse analysis benefit each other in the whole analytic process, contributing to a proper understanding of the different ways of imagining Hong Kong's relations to China by the three former CEs at different levels of discourse. It is hoped that it can lead to growing CADS towards this endeavour.

Author contributions

Ming Liu (Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Funding acquisition, Investigation, Methodology, Project administration, Resources, Software, Supervision, Validation, Visualization, Writing—original draft, Writing—review & editing)

Conflict of interest statement. The authors report there are no competing interests to declare.

Funding

This work was supported by The Hong Kong Polytechnic University UGC (Grant number: 1-BE68).

Data availability

The data underlying this article are available in The Hong Kong Government Portal at https://www.ceo.gov.hk/en/speeches.html.

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